

Semester SaaS Launch Kit

Purpose: A business-operating template for launching Semester as a unified university operating system: corporate setup, institutional pilot terms, module packaging/pricing, insurance readiness, and a higher-education go-to-market plan.

Important: This is a commercial planning template, not legal, tax, accounting, insurance, or investment advice. Engage qualified startup counsel, higher-education/privacy counsel, a CPA, and an insurance broker before signing customer contracts, forming an entity, issuing equity, collecting payments, or representing compliance.

1. Launch operating model

Semester's commercial position

Semester is a unified, modular university operating system. It combines student planning, learning and native-LMS capabilities, study/work-completion tools, career, campus life, services, AI governance, interoperability, and institutional controls through shared identity, permissions, trust, accessibility, and operations infrastructure.

One platform agreement
+ Foundation platform entitlement
+ Institution-configured modules
+ Implementation scope
+ Support tier
+ Transparent usage/cost guardrails

Core commercial rules

- The Foundation platform is required for institutional use.
- Privacy, accessibility, export, security, and core data controls are never premium.
- Every module has a named product owner, operational owner, data model, support model, accessibility requirements, and implementation playbook before sale.
- Implementation, migration, custom development, and premium support are separately scoped.
- AI and storage costs require explicit allowance, cap, customer-managed account, or opt-out.
- No sale of student data, hidden student behavior, academic data, accommodation data, basic-needs activity, or private AI conversations.
- Employers/partners may purchase approved services, not undisclosed student access.

2. Delaware C-Corp setup checklist

Entity decision

A Delaware C-Corporation is often considered when a technology company expects to raise venture capital, issue equity/options, build enterprise relationships, or operate as a long-lived scalable business. An LLC can be appropriate for a bootstrapped or service-oriented business. Select the structure with startup counsel and a CPA based on funding, tax, ownership, and operating plans.

Formation steps

- [] Retain startup counsel and CPA.
- [] Clear proposed company name and domain/trademark conflicts.
- [] Choose Delaware C-Corp, LLC, or another approved structure.
- [] Appoint a registered agent.
- [] File certificate of incorporation or formation documents.
- [] Obtain EIN and required state/local registrations.
- [] Adopt bylaws or operating agreement.
- [] Appoint initial directors, officers, and authorized signers.
- [] Approve founder stock/equity grants and maintain a cap table.
- [] Execute founder invention/IP assignment and confidentiality agreements.
- [] Create equity incentive plan before meaningful hiring, if appropriate.
- [] Evaluate 83(b) election requirements with counsel/tax advisor.
- [] Open company bank account and payment-processor account.
- [] Implement accounting system, chart of accounts, expense approvals, and monthly c
- [] Register for required payroll, sales/use tax, and local tax obligations.
- [] Establish contract-signature authority and legal review process.
- [] Execute employee, contractor, advisor confidentiality and IP-assignment agreement
- [] Adopt records retention, privacy, security, accessibility, and AI governance pol:
- [] Establish board/advisor governance, meeting records, and corporate document repos

Essential corporate files

Certificate of incorporation / formation documents
Bylaws or operating agreement
Board and stockholder consents
Cap table and equity records
Founder stock purchase documents
IP assignment documents
Employee/contractor/advisor agreements
EIN confirmation and tax registrations
Banking resolutions
Insurance policies and certificates
Trademark/domain documentation
Policy register and corporate records schedule

3. Insurance readiness checklist

Recommended coverage sequence

Coverage	Trigger	Purpose	Broker questions
Commercial General Liability	Formation, office/venue/customer contract requirement	Third-party bodily injury, property damage, certain advertising injury claims	Required limits, additional-insured terms, worldwide territory
Technology E&O / Professional Liability	Before paid pilots and enterprise contracts	Claims caused by software/service error, failure to perform, or professional negligence	Does it cover SaaS outage, implementation failure, content/AI-related professional exposure?
Cyber Liability	Before production personal/student/customer data	Breach response, forensics, notification, ransomware, cyber business interruption	Does it cover privacy claims, regulatory response, vendor incidents, social engineering?
Directors & Officers	Before outside financing, formal board, or priced round	Management, governance, and fiduciary claims	Does it include entity coverage and appropriate retention?
Employment Practices Liability	At employee hiring or as part of D&O package	Employment-related allegations	Multi-state workforce and contractor treatment?
Workers' Compensation	When legally required for employees in relevant states	Work-related injury obligations	Which employee locations trigger coverage?
Crime / Social Engineering	When payments, AP, wire transfers, or vendor disbursements mature	Fraud, funds-transfer, and employee dishonesty risk	Are payment-processor/wire-fraud losses covered?
Media/IP	As public content, AI, marketplace, and brand activity expand	Some media, copyright, or IP claims subject to exclusions	What AI/content exclusions apply?

Insurance underwriting packet

- [] Legal entity, ownership, revenue, projected revenue, employee/contractor count.
- [] Product description, customer type, and high-risk workflows.
- [] Security overview and architecture diagram.
- [] MFA, encryption, logging, backups, incident response, vulnerability management en
- [] Privacy policy, DPA, subprocessor list, retention policy, and AI data-use policy
- [] Description of student/education-record data and safeguards.
- [] Prior claims/incidents and remediation, if any.
- [] Contractual insurance requirements from target institutions.
- [] Requested limits, deductibles/retentions, exclusions, and certificate requiremen

4. Pilot agreement terms and conditions

Recommended agreement package

1. Pilot Agreement or Master Services Agreement
 2. Order Form / Pilot Statement of Work
 3. Data Processing Addendum
 4. Security, Privacy, Accessibility, and AI Exhibit
 5. Support and Service-Level Exhibit
 6. Implementation Plan and Launch Gates
 7. Optional Business Associate / payment / other regulated-data exhibit only if applicable

Pilot term sheet

Term	Recommended position
Parties	Semester legal entity and named institution legal entity
Term	One academic term or 90–180 days, with explicit start/end dates
Scope	Named cohort, modules, environments, integrations, and user roles only
Purpose	Validate a defined student/institution outcome, not general unlimited use
Fees	Paid pilot; invoice schedule and taxes stated; optional credit toward annual license only if specified
Cohort	Defined covered population, institution/program/campus, and enrollment cap
Data	Minimum necessary; approved data map; no data outside defined scope
Customer authority	Institution retains official authority for registration, degree audit, financial aid, discipline, accommodations, health, and final decisions
AI	No general-purpose training on production customer/student data by default; approved provider/data use only
Support	Named contacts, hours, severity framework, escalation route, and explicit non-emergency boundary
Success	Baseline, target, methods, data owner, review dates, and end-of-pilot value review
Publicity	No logo, case study, testimonial, or outcome claim without written customer approval
Conversion	Pre-agreed option and decision date; no automatic conversion unless legally/contractually intended
Exit	Export, transition support, deletion/retention, credential revocation, and closeout requirements

Draft pilot terms

1. Pilot scope

Semester will provide Customer access to the Semester platform solely for the Pilot Purpose described in the applicable Order Form. The Order Form will identify the Pilot cohort, enabled modules, permitted environments, integration scope, approved user roles, implementation milestones, and excluded functionality.

Any functionality, integration, custom development, service level, data category, or user population not expressly listed in the Order Form is excluded from the Pilot

2. Customer responsibilities

Customer will designate an executive sponsor, operational owner, technical contact, privacy/security contact, accessibility contact, and support escalation contacts. Customer is responsible for the accuracy, authority, rights, and timeliness of Customer-provided content, policies, source information, user eligibility, and institutional decisions.

Customer will provide required approvals, test users, configuration information, identity/integration access, and launch communications on the mutually agreed timeline. Customer will not upload or provide data outside the approved data map.

3. Semester responsibilities

Semester will provide the enabled services, configuration, agreed implementation activities, documentation, training, and support described in the Order Form and Implementation Plan. Semester will maintain administrative, technical, and organizational safeguards appropriate to the services and data scope, as described in the applicable agreement exhibits.

4. Institutional authority and product boundaries

Semester supports planning, learning, routing, communication, and authorized workflows. Unless expressly agreed in writing, Semester does not replace Customer's systems of record and does not make official determinations regarding admissions, registration, degree conferral, transfer credit, financial aid, billing, discipline, accommodations, health, legal matters, emergency response, or other high-impact institutional decisions.

Customer retains responsibility for official academic, institutional, and service eligibility decisions. AI-assisted outputs are not official determinations and require appropriate human/institutional review under Customer policy.

5. Data, privacy, and AI

Customer retains all rights in Customer Data. Semester may process Customer Data only to provide, secure, support, and improve the Services in accordance with the Agreement, Data Processing Addendum, documented instructions, and applicable law.

Semester will not sell Customer Data or use Customer Data, Student Content, education records, private conversations, uploads, or production AI prompts/outputs to train general-purpose AI models by default. Any different arrangement requires a separate, written, specifically approved agreement and applicable controls.

The parties will document approved data categories, sources, integrations, purposes, retention, and access roles in the data map. Customer will obtain any required notices, consents, or institutional approvals for Customer-directed data use.

6. Security and incident communication

Semester will maintain security safeguards described in the applicable security exhibit. Semester will notify Customer of confirmed security incidents involving Customer Data in accordance with the agreed notification procedure and applicable law. The parties will cooperate in good faith on investigation, containment, communications, and remediation.

7. Accessibility

Semester will provide the then-current accessibility documentation identified in the Order Form and maintain a process for accessibility feedback and remediation. Customer is responsible for the accessibility of Customer-authored content unless Semester expressly provides an approved remediation service. The parties will identify known limitations, alternatives, and remediation priorities during implementation.

8. Support and service operation

Support scope, hours, severity definitions, escalation contacts, maintenance windows, service objectives, and exclusions are set forth in the Support Exhibit. Semester is not an emergency, medical, mental-health, legal, or crisis-response service unless a separate, specifically staffed and contracted service provides otherwise.

9. Fees and payment

Customer will pay the Pilot fees and approved implementation fees stated in the Order Form. Fees are non-refundable except as expressly stated in the Agreement. Any pilot credit toward a subsequent annual subscription must be stated in the Order Form, must have a conversion deadline, and does not apply to third-party fees, custom development, or implementation services unless expressly stated.

10. Pilot evaluation and conversion

The parties will conduct periodic pilot reviews and an end-of-pilot value review using the agreed success measures. Neither party is obligated to enter a subsequent agreement unless the Order Form expressly states otherwise. Any annual subscription, expanded scope, or production integration requires a separate order form or amendment.

11. Termination and transition

Upon expiration or termination, Customer may export eligible Customer Data in the documented format during the agreed transition period. Semester will disable Customer access and process deletion or return of Customer Data in accordance with the DPA, retention schedule, applicable law, and any valid legal hold. Customer is responsible for revoking or rotating Customer-controlled integration credentials.

12. Legal provisions requiring counsel

Confidentiality
Intellectual property and feedback
Warranties and disclaimers
Indemnification
Limitation of liability
Insurance
Governing law and venue
Assignment
Force majeure
Notices
Publicity
Export controls and sanctions

5. Module pricing model

Commercial architecture

Foundation platform (required)
+ learning / student life / pathways / control-plane modules
+ implementation and migration
+ support tier
+ transparent AI, storage, transaction, and custom-work guardrails

Modules and pricing metrics

Module	Buyer	Pricing metric	Included value	Pricing guardrail
Semester Foundation	Institution, department, program	Enrollment band, covered cohort, or campus scope	Identity/context, Today, planning, tasks/calendar, source/scope/status, account/data controls, search, notifications	Required for institutional modules
Academic Navigation	Student success, advising, transfer	Covered students or program scope	Plan, advisor agenda, verified service routing, transition workflows	Never represents official audit/registration by default
Learning & LMS	Academic affairs, online learning	Active course enrollments or institution band	Course workspace, content, work completion, Study Studio, course AI policy	Separate high-stakes assessment scope if needed

Module	Buyer	Pricing metric	Included value	Pricing guardrail
Assessment & Gradebook	Academic affairs	Active course enrollments / high-stakes scope	QTI, rubrics, delivery, feedback, grade ledger	Sell only with mature support, audit, and accessibility controls
Student Life & Community	Student affairs	Institution band or active community users	Clubs, events, mentorship, community/service discovery, moderation controls	Safety/moderation scope must match staffing model
Student Support Navigator	Student success, basic-needs/transfer offices	Institution band or service-network scope	Resource directory, handoffs, source freshness, referral controls	Sensitive intake requires restricted workflow and explicit owner
Career & Pathways	Career services, experiential learning	Covered students or active users	Opportunities, portfolio, skills evidence, alumni/employer workflows	No sale of student data or hidden employer targeting
AI Control Center	CIO, provost, teaching/learning	Institution band plus AI use tier	Policy, provider controls, approved sources, evaluation, governance	Include allowance/cap/customer-managed model account
Institutional Control Plane	CIO, IT, security	Institution band	Audit/evidence, integration health, retention/consent, admin controls	Include core security/privacy/accessibility controls
Interoperability Pack	CIO, IT	Per integration family / enterprise tier	SSO, SCIM, LTI, OneRoster, APIs, webhooks, data map, sync health	Custom integrations require separate SOW
Payments/Transactions	Campus operations	Transaction fee plus operating scope	Approved payments, ticketing, dues, receipts/reconciliation	Later-stage; processor compliance and policy required
Premium Support/Success	Institution	Fixed annual tier or percentage of annual subscription	Named CSM, priority support, office hours, health review, training	Do not promise 24/7 unless staffed and contracted

Starting commercial bands

These are starting hypotheses to test through discovery. They are not published pricing commitments.

Scope	Annual software hypothesis	One-time implementation hypothesis	Suitable motion
Individual student	Free tier; \$8–25/month paid tier	None	Product-led adoption
Department/program pilot	\$10,000–30,000	\$5,000–20,000	Paid pilot / defined cohort
Small institutional deployment	\$30,000–90,000	\$15,000–75,000	Foundation + one/two modules
Mid-market institution	\$90,000–250,000	\$50,000–200,000	Multiple modules, SSO, integration, enablement
Large/enterprise university	\$250,000–750,000+	\$150,000–500,000+	Multi-year platform agreement, governance, integration, premium support

Price calculator inputs

Institution enrollment band
Covered population or active course enrollments
Campuses/entities
Enabled module set
SSO/SCIM/LTI/OneRoster/API integration families
Data migration volume and complexity
Customer content/source-directory readiness
AI model, allowance, and expected task volume
Storage and file-processing requirements
Support tier and named-service requirements
Implementation timeline and staffing
Security/privacy/accessibility/compliance requirements
Custom development scope
Contract length and payment terms

6. Higher-education go-to-market plan

Market position

Semester is the unified, source-aware, accessible, governed operating system for the full university journey.

For students:

Know what matters, what is official, what to do next, and who can help.

For institutions:

Connect existing systems and services into a secure, interoperable, measurable, and student-centered experience without sacrificing institutional authority.

Ideal early customer profiles

Transfer-intensive institutions and transfer centers
Community colleges and regional public universities
Student-success and advising organizations
Accessibility-forward institutions
Institutions with fragmented service/resource landscapes
Large gateway-course or academic-support programs
Career and experiential-learning teams
Institutions formalizing campus AI governance

Buyer map

Buyer	Pain	Message	Initial offer
VP/AVP Student Success	Students cannot find correct next actions or support	One source-aware student action layer	Academic Navigation pilot
Transfer Center Director	Transfer students lose time/context across systems	Transfer transition operating system with official-source routing	Transfer Hub pilot
CIO/CISO	Fragmented tools, shadow AI, integration and audit burden	Governed standards-first platform/control plane	Control-plane/AI discovery workshop
Provost/Academic Affairs	Inconsistent learning support and course AI practice	Course-aware Study Studio, work completion, accessibility, and policy	Learning/AI pilot
Student Affairs leader	Community, clubs, events, and services are disconnected	Governed belonging and service-discovery operating layer	Student Life pilot
Career Services leader	Academic work is disconnected from workforce evidence	Skills/evidence, portfolio, opportunities, and student-controlled sharing	Career Pathways pilot

180-day GTM sequence

Days 1–30: Market and sales readiness

- [] Finalize category narrative, ideal-customer profile, and buyer-specific messaging
- [] Publish company website, trust center, accessibility, AI transparency, system boundaries, and pilot landing page.
- [] Create synthetic demonstration tenant and guided demo script.
- [] Complete baseline procurement room: security overview, DPA, privacy policy, subprocessor list, accessibility statement, AI policy, implementation outline.
- [] Create pilot agreement, order form, SOW, pricing calculator, and proposal template
- [] Build target account list of 50-100 institutions/programs.
- [] Conduct 15-25 structured buyer-discovery interviews.
- [] Recruit 3-5 design partners.

Days 31–90: Sell and launch pilots

- [] Convert qualified discovery into 1-3 paid, bounded pilots.
- [] Run implementation/readiness workshops with each pilot.
- [] Configure source content, roles, accessibility, AI policy, and integrations.
- [] Train staff, faculty/advisors, student champions, and support contacts.
- [] Launch communications, onboarding, office hours, and hypercare.
- [] Measure activation, clarity, verified-resource discovery, support handoff, accessibility success, implementation effort, and stakeholder value.
- [] Hold weekly pilot reviews and publish a 30-day evidence report to each customer.

Days 91–180: Turn pilots into repeatability

- [] Conduct midpoint and final value reviews.
- [] Convert pilots to annual contracts with modular expansion plan.
- [] Standardize implementation templates, integration patterns, configuration default training, runbooks, and evidence reports.
- [] Obtain customer references/case-study approval only when results are verified.
- [] Publish practitioner resources: Academic Friction diagnostic, Transfer Navigation Playbook, Accessible Learning Toolkit, Campus AI Governance Canvas.
- [] Build partner relationships: higher-ed consultants, accessibility specialists, systems integrators, and relevant standards communities.

Channel plan

Channel	Purpose	First action
Founder-led outbound	Find and learn from high-fit institutional buyers	Personalized message around transfer, navigation, governed AI, or accessibility friction
LinkedIn	Executive credibility and distribution	Weekly evidence-led posts, short workflow videos, research findings, webinar promotion
Website/SEO	Convert intent and build trust	Audience pages, Trust Center, pilot CTA, synthetic demo, procurement library
Webinars/clinics	Demonstrate expertise before sale	Transfer navigation, accessible assessment, campus AI governance, service-content operations
Conferences/associations	Reach qualified institutional networks	EDUCAUSE, 1EdTech, NACADA, NASPA, transfer/community-college/accessibility/career communities
Student product-led growth	Create real end-user demand	Free personal planning/study value with clear nonofficial source labels and privacy boundary
Partnerships	Extend reach and implementation capacity	Consultants, accessibility partners, system integrators, higher-ed associations

Sales process

Target account
→ personalized problem hypothesis
→ discovery meeting
→ workflow/stakeholder/current-stack map
→ tailored synthetic demo
→ security/accessibility/AI/integration qualification
→ paid-pilot design workshop
→ proposal and procurement room
→ contract
→ implementation readiness
→ pilot launch
→ midpoint review
→ annual conversion and module-expansion plan

Core pipeline metrics

Target accounts contacted
Positive-response rate
Discovery meetings
Qualified opportunities
Pilot-design workshops
Pilot proposals
Pilot win rate
Sales cycle length
Pilot implementation duration
Pilot activation rate
Pilot-to-annual conversion
Annual contract value
Implementation margin
Gross margin by tenant/module
Expansion pipeline
Renewal rate
Reference/case-study permission rate

7. Product Governance Council charter

Purpose

The Semester Product Governance Council ensures that enabled platform capabilities advance Semester's mission while balancing student value, institutional authority, security, privacy, accessibility, AI safety, reliability, operational supportability, commercial viability, and evidence-based claims.

Scope

New modules and material features
New data uses and integrations
AI models/providers/policies/evaluations/tool actions
Assessment, grading, integrity, and student-record workflows
Accessibility requirements, known limitations, and remediation
Community, mentoring, moderation, safety, and sensitive-support workflows
Identity, permissions, sharing, retention, deletion, and export behavior
Customer-impacting releases and public product claims
Risk exceptions and release-gate waivers

Membership

Role	Core responsibility
Chair / Product executive	Strategy, agenda, prioritization, decision record
Engineering leader	Architecture, delivery, technical debt, reliability
Security lead	Security risk, access, incidents, vendor controls
Privacy/legal lead	Data use, contracts, FERPA/privacy, retention/legal holds
Accessibility lead	WCAG, disabled-user impact, ACR/VPAT, remediation gates
AI governance lead	Models/providers, evaluations, policy, misuse controls
Customer success lead	Deployability, training, support and adoption impact
Design/research lead	Usability, user evidence, interaction quality
Institutional advisor	University workflow and authority perspective
Student advisor	Student agency, clarity, belonging, accessibility perspective
Finance/commercial lead	Pricing, entitlement, contract, margin impact
Operations/SRE lead	Monitoring, incident readiness, operational supportability

Required decision packet

Problem and target outcome
Affected users/stakeholders and institutional owner
Scope and non-goals
Workflow/user journey
Data map, classification, retention, and sharing behavior
Permission and tenant-isolation model
Source / Scope / Status behavior
Accessibility requirements and test plan
Security threat model and control plan
AI provider/model/policy/evaluation plan, if applicable
Integration/data-map impact, if applicable
Support/runbook/incident plan
Pricing, entitlement, implementation and margin impact

Metrics, risks, residual risk, rollback/disable plan
Required approvals, evidence, and release gates

Approval outcomes

Approved
Approved with conditions
Pilot only
Deferred pending evidence
Rejected
Escalated for executive/legal/customer decision

Release blocks

Do not release when a P0/P1 security, privacy, accessibility, grade-integrity, or reliability issue is open.

Do not release without named product/operational/support owners.

Do not release without documented data flow, permission, retention, and source-authority behavior.

Do not release high-risk AI/integration capability without evaluation, sandbox validation, monitoring, and disable/rollback controls.

Do not publish a compliance, certification, accessibility, security, or outcome claim without linked evidence and approval.

8. First 30-day execution checklist

- [] Select entity path with counsel and CPA.
- [] Form entity, establish banking/accounting, execute founder IP assignment, establish cap table and contracting authority.
- [] Engage insurance broker; bind CGL, Cyber, and Technology E&O as appropriate.
- [] Finalize pilot agreement package and legal review.
- [] Finalize Foundation/modules/implementation/support entitlement model.
- [] Establish pilot and annual price floors plus discount approval workflow.
- [] Form Product Governance Council and assign interim owners.
- [] Build procurement room and synthetic demo tenant.
- [] Build first 50-100 account list and buyer contacts.
- [] Conduct 15-25 discovery conversations.
- [] Recruit 3-5 design partners and sell the first paid pilot.
- [] Establish weekly pipeline, product-risk, customer-readiness, and financial review

9. Final operating principle

Semester sells a unified platform.

Pilots prove connected outcomes.

Annual contracts activate modules in governed waves.

Implementation is repeatable, paid, and evidence-led.

Governance protects the student, institution, and company.

Trust, accessibility, interoperability, and operational reliability are product features.